

Birds and everything about them makes me think of the old days. Of the time when I went on vacation to the Veluwe (a forest-rich ridge of hills in the Netherlands) with my grandparents. Much of the time we spent there was spent searching and watching birds, which we loved. With the cooperative bird game Tureluurs, I may be able to relive those old times, because in this game we will be bird watching!

What is Tureluurs?

'Ik word er helemaal tureluurs van!' is a Dutch expression and means something like 'It's making me crazy!'. In Dutch, the word Tureluurs is used to describe that something is repetitive and therefor making you completely mad or crazy. However, a Tureluur (a common redshank) is also a threatened species of bird that can be found in several places in the Netherlands.

Okay, but what kind of game is it?

Tureluurs is a cooperative card game for two to four players which is set in 1899, the year De Vogelbescherming (Society for the Protection of Birds) was founded. Players are sent into the field together to spot birds. To win, they must spot at least one bird from each of the four bird families in the game. Of course, this does not happen without a struggle, as there are all sorts of dangers lurking that could just scare the birds away. Moreover, the birds must be registered in the Bird Guide before the end of the bird season.

There is also a solo variant in the game.

How is the game played?

There are four types of cards in the game:

- Birds;
- Hours ('Tuururen');
- Events;
- Bird Skills.

The Bird Skills are placed face up on the table, under the Bird Guide. The rest of the cards are shuffled and form the draw pile.

On their turn, a player has two options: either take a card from the draw pile and play it immediately, or give a Bird card or Event to another player.

When you take a Bird card (identified by the feather on the back of the card) from the draw pile, you place this bird in front of you. Each player has room for up to two birds. If you receive a third Bird card, you must therefore choose which bird to discard, you may decide this in consultation with your fellow players.

If the card drawn is an Event, you execute it immediately unless otherwise indicated. Events have different effects that can be negative or positive: some, for example, cause your birds to fly away and another allows you to take back a Bird card from the discard pile.

The cards around which the game ultimately revolves are the 'Tuururen'. These are cards with numbers (5, 10, 20 or 50) on them and you use them to spot birds or to use Birding Skills. On Bird Cards and Bird Skills there is also a number that indicates how many Hours are needed to spot the bird or activate the skill. If you draw a Tuururen card from the deck, you must immediately assign it to a bird or skill. You may not put down Tuururen to a bird of your fellow player(s). When enough Hours are assigned to a Bird card, the bird is spotted and you place the card on the Bird Guide.

End scoring

Players collectively win the game once at least one bird of each bird family is spotted. Add the numbers of the remaining Tuururen cards on the draw pile and divide the result by two. You then add that result to the Tuururen on the Bird Cards in the Bird Guide to determine the final score.

Everyone loses if the draw pile is empty before there is at least one bird from each family on the Bird Guide. The birding season is over and our feathered friends all migrated.

Solo variant

Tureluurs can also be played solo. It then works virtually the same as a multiplayer game, with the major difference being that you play each turn with a hand of five cards, three of which you choose to play. In doing so, you are required to play Events first. The two remaining cards go to the discard pile at the end of your turn. In addition, there are a few Events that have been slightly modified. The scoring is the same as in the base game. What do I think of Tureluurs?

Theme

The theme of the game is actually reflected in the game play and I can really appreciate that. Bird watching requires a lot of patience and can be frustrating at the same time. Having to be patient is nicely simulated in the game by the Hours and the frustration can get quite a bit with the Events where the birds you are trying to find and record suddenly fly away. The fact that players lose when bird season is over also makes sense: many birds don't stay in the same place all year and won't be seen after the season ends.

Design

Tureluurs is a nice, small card game. There are sixteen Bird Cards in the game, all based on drawings from Nozeman & Sepp's "Nederlandsche Vogelen".

The graphics on the rest of the cards were generated with AI (Artificial Intelligence), but fortunately that doesn't detract from the charm of the game. I like the fact that the text on the cards is not too large, this leaves more space for the graphics and that certainly benefits the game. Although you can't really read the cards from the other side of the table, so you really have to pick them up or at least have them in front of you on the table, the effects of the cards are simple and easy to remember. Soon enough, just the picture is enough and reading the text is no longer necessary. This also certainly makes for a smoother game play.

Gameplay

The rules and principle of Tureluurs are very simple: draw a card, play a card. The option to be able to give away cards to another player can be a useful tool. However, I cannot say that it causes thoughtful and tactical choices to be made throughout the game. It remains a card game where you depend on a bit of luck to grab the right cards at the right time. For example, we lost a game due to pure, dumb luck: there were five cards left in the draw pile and one bird had yet to be spotted. This one was with me and needed twenty more Hours. The cards with five ended up with me and my fellow player obviously grabbed the one with twenty. Let me just say that you have to keep in mind that luck can play a big role in this game.

Final verdict

Tureluurs is a very suitable game for afternoons with coffee or any other “moment of rest” in the day. It comes easily to the table, looks nice and is easy to learn. Trying to improve the final score is a fun challenge, and it's a plus that there's also a great solo variant (you do drink coffee alone sometimes, right?). If you prefer to play something where luck is narrowly involved, then this is not a good choice for you. In terms of balance, sixteen Bird Cards are a logical move, yet I would have liked to have had some extra birds to choose from. Should these ever appear in an expansion, I would gladly add them to the base game for some more variety. I really enjoy playing Tureluurs, but prefer not to play too many and/or too often. It is just as welcome an addition to the assortment of games that serve as filler.

Vogelbescherming Nederland has been dedicated to the protection of all wild birds and their habitats since 1899. Per copy of Tureluurs sold, a contribution is also made to Vogelbescherming through royalties. For more information visit the website of Tureluurs Games